

paying utility bills, the ubiquitous ATM is the new all-purpose, one-stop shop in an age when the customer is the king. Explains Madhabi Puri Buch, senior general manager at ICICI Bank, "The transformation has been driven by the availability of technology and customers' need for 24X7 banking."

The number of ATMs has increased by 20 per cent from 17,642 in 2005 to 21,000 in 2006, symbolising India's economic transformation. From the launch of the first ATM in 1994, the machine has come a long way. It is now capable of multiple services ranging from dealing in mutual funds to making donations to one's favourite temple. With the launch of mobile ATMs, banks are now reaching out to consumers who may find it difficult to reach even the nearest ATM kiosk. These mobile machines have proved to be a godsend in times of natural calamities, as was the case during the floods in Surat last year, when they were deployed to facilitate dispensing of cash. In time, a lot more will be possible with technology. Citibank already has biometric authentication at some of its ATMs while the ATMs of IDBI Bank offer airline and movie tickets. It's just a machine, did anyone say?

Their idea of fun is killing terrorists with state-of-the-art weapons. These young men have made it their business to play games.

■ By Chitra Subramanyam

The cuss words flow, fast and furious. The five young men stare at their computer screens, headphones in place, their fingers tapping incessantly. They spare no glance at the five others facing them, mirroring their actions. "Are you watching my back?" one of them shouts. A sudden red splotch and the screen turning black is his answer. He's dead. The four other screens fade. A cry goes up and the opposing team exchanges high-fives. They've won this round of Counter-Strike, one of the most popular online first-person shooter games in the world.

PROFESSIONAL GAMERS

DELHI



Shooting at site

This is no hole-in-the-wall video game parlour, the kind parents warn their children about. Nor is it a haven for truant boys who indulge in a daily three-hour bloodletting fest. These professional gamers are competing in the World Cyber Games preliminaries to represent their country in Seattle, US. The challenges are many—self-styled top clans struggle for sponsorships and battle parents among other things. Like 21-year-old Shiv Anand Krishnan, who balances his studies, a job and working on his Counter-Strike skills. Parental support came when he started

winning tournaments. Fellow clan member 19-year-old Shyamrup Choudhury says his mother came around when she realised the game meant a lot to him though his father hasn't converted to the cause.

The two, along with three others, formed Revolution, the best Counter-Strike specialists in north India.

And their passion sees them practising every month, when fellow teamer Siddhartha Hans, 17, comes down from Jalandhar. And while people prefer to think of them as a bunch of children at playtime, for these professionals, it's virtual reality.

Rs21
CR IS THE SIZE
OF INDIA'S ON-
LINE GAMING
INDUSTRY

BANDEEP SINGH



TEAM REVOLUTION: (Clockwise from left) Choudhury, John Charles Colognesse, Himanshu Dhall and Hans